Questions matter

A-level
ENGLISH LITERATURE A
Mark scheme guidance and application

Pre-event marking booklet

Published: Summer 2025

Before you attend the Mark scheme guidance and application training event, **please mark the student responses in this booklet** by adding your marks to this pdf or writing them in your own notebook.

You can discuss your marking with delegates at the event and see how it compares to that of the examiner.

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Question 1 Paper 1, June 2024

***Othello* – William Shakespeare**

'In *Othello*, Iago's skills make him a likeable anti-hero rather than a hateful villain.'

In the light of this view, discuss how Shakespeare presents Iago's attitudes to love in this extract and elsewhere in the play.

[25 marks]

IAGO Come, come; good wine is a good familiar creature if it be well used: exclaim no more against it. And, good Lieutenant, I think you think I love you.
CASSIO I have well approved it, sir. I drunk!
IAGO You or any man living may be drunk at a time, man. I'll tell you what you shall do. Our General's wife is now the General. I may say so in this respect, for that he hath devoted and given up himself to the contemplation, mark, and denotement of her parts and graces. Confess yourself freely to her; importune her help to put you in your place again. She is of so free, so kind, so apt, so blessed a disposition, that she holds it a vice in her goodness not to do more than she is requested. This broken joint between you and her husband, entreat her to splinter; and my fortunes against any lay worth naming, this crack of your love shall grow stronger than it was before.
CASSIO You advise me well.
IAGO I protest in the sincerity of love and honest kindness.
CASSIO I think it freely; and betimes in the morning I will beseech the virtuous Desdemona to undertake for me. I am desperate of my fortunes if they check me here.
IAGO You are in the right. Good night, Lieutenant, I must to the watch.
CASSIO Good night, honest Iago. *Exit*
IAGO
And what's he then that says I play the villain,
When this advice is free I give, and honest,
Probal to thinking, and indeed the course
To win the Moor again? For 'tis most easy
Th'inclining Desdemona to subdue
In any honest suit. She's framed as fruitful
As the free elements; and then for her
To win the Moor, were't to renounce his baptism,
All seals and symbols of redeemèd sin,
His soul is so enfettered to her love,
That she may make, unmake, do what she list,

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Even as her appetite shall play the god
With his weak function. How am I then a villain
To counsel Cassio to this parallel course
Directly to his good? Divinity of hell!
When devils will the blackest sins put on,
They do suggest at first with heavenly shows
As I do now. For whiles this honest fool
Plies Desdemona to repair his fortunes
And she for him pleads strongly to the Moor,
I'll pour this pestilence into his ear:
That she repeals him for her body's lust,
And by how much she strives to do him good,
She shall undo her credit with the Moor.
So will I turn her virtue into pitch,
And out of her own goodness make the net
That shall enmesh them all.

(Act 2, Scene 3)

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Mark scheme

It is important to remember that these students, in the main, are 18 years old so we are judging their skills at the end of Key Stage 5.

Weightings for each question are as follows:

AO1: 7 marks AO2: 6 marks AO3: 6 marks AO4: 3 marks AO5: 3 marks.

Mark	AO	Typical features	How to arrive at mark
Band 5 **Perceptive/Assured** **21–25 marks** '**Perception**' is demonstrated when students are showing the depth of their understanding and responding sensitively to the texts and task. '**Assuredness**' is shown when students write with confidence and conviction.	AO5	• perceptive and confident engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **perceptive** and **assured** work which shows confidence, sharpness of mind and sophistication in relation to the task. At the top of the band students are consistently **assured** and will demonstrate sensitivity and **perception** across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band there will be coherence and accuracy with some **perception** but with less consistency and evenness.
	AO4	• perceptive exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• perceptive understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • assuredness in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• perceptive understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • assured engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• perceptive, assured and sophisticated argument in relation to the task • assured use of literary critical concepts and terminology; mature and impressive expression	

Band 4 **Coherent/Thorough** **16–20 marks** '**Coherence**' is shown when students are logical and consistent in their arguments in relation to the task. They hold their ideas together in an intelligible way. '**Thoroughness**' is shown when students write carefully, precisely and accurately.	AO5	• thorough engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **coherent** and **thorough** work where ideas are linked together in a focused and purposeful way in relation to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a fully **coherent** and **thorough** argument across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band ideas will be discussed in a shaped, relevant and purposeful way with a clear sense of direction, with one or two lapses in **coherence** and accuracy.
	AO4	• logical and consistent exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• thorough understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • coherence in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• thorough understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • thorough engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• logical, thorough and coherent argument in relation to the task where ideas are debated in depth • appropriate use of literary critical concepts and terminology; precise and accurate expression	

Band 3 **Straightforward/** **Relevant** **11–15 marks** '**Straightforward**' work is shown when students make their ideas in relation to the task clearly known. '**Relevant**' work is shown when students are focused on the task and use detail in an appropriate and supportive way.	AO5	• straightforward engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **straightforward** and **relevant** work where the student's response to the task is clear and intelligible. At the top of the band students will demonstrate consistent **straightforward** understanding in the course of their argument. Ideas will be developed **relevantly**. At the bottom of the band there will be flashes of **relevant** understanding with evidence of **straightforward** thinking.
	AO4	• explores connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study in a straightforward way	
	AO3	• straightforward understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • relevant connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• straightforward understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • relevant engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• sensibly ordered ideas in a relevant argument in relation to the task • some use of literary critical concepts and terminology which are mainly appropriate; straightforward and clear expression	

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Band 2 **Simple/Generalised** **6–10 marks** '**Simple**' work is shown when students write in an unelaborated and basic way in relation to the task. '**Generalised**' work is shown when students write without regard to particular details.	AO5	• simple and generalised response to the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **simple** and **generalised** work which is mainly linked to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a basic **generalised** understanding in the course of their answer. Ideas will be developed in a **simple** way. At the bottom of the band there will be inconsistency, but the beginnings of a **simple** and **generalised** understanding.
	AO4	• simple exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• simple understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • generalised connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• simple understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • generalised engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• a simple structure to the argument which may not be consistent but which does relate to the task • generalised use of literary critical concepts and terminology; simple expression	

Band 1 **Largely irrelevant/largely misunderstood/largely inaccurate** **1–5 marks** '**Largely irrelevant**' work is shown when students write in an unclear way with only occasional reference to what is required by the question. '**Largely misunderstood**' and '**largely inaccurate**' work is shown when knowledge of the text is insecure, hazy and often wrong.		• some vague points in relation to the task and some ideas about task and text(s) • the writing is likely to be unclear and incorrect; if it is accurate the content will be irrelevant • little sense of the AOs in relation to the task; little sense of how meanings are shaped; little sense of any relevant contexts; little sense of any connection arising out of historicist study; little sense of an argument in relation to the task	This band is characterised by work which is **largely irrelevant** and **largely misunderstood** and **largely inaccurate**, and so unlikely to be addressing the AOs in a relevant way. At the top of the band students will mention some unconnected points in relation to the task during the course of their writing. The writing is likely to lack clarity. At the bottom of the band there will be no connection with the task; the writing will be hard to follow and **irrelevant**.
0 marks		No marks for response when nothing is written or where response has no connection to the text(s) or task.	

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AO5 Explore literary texts informed by different interpretations

Students might consider:

- the purpose of the critical view is to provoke debate about ways of reading Iago rather than testing knowledge of definitions of anti-hero and villain
- Iago's account of the relationship between Othello and Desdemona offered as a source of hope and reassurance for Cassio
- the way in which he reassures Cassio that all will be well
- the ways in which Iago presents himself as keen to enjoy drinking and friendship
- the ways in which he presents his advice to Cassio using 'macho' posturing and gossip about Othello and Desdemona's relationship
- Iago's orchestration of Cassio's drunkenness and susceptibility to Iago's plan
- the way in which he can now appear to be a friend to Cassio by furthering his cause but at the same time his own
- the embellishment of his speeches to Cassio with perceptive insights into Desdemona's nature
- his view that Desdemona is easy prey
- his witty use of religious ideas
- his wordplay around the term 'villain'
- the change of mood in the soliloquy
- his use of Satanic imagery and dark threats of destruction
- the idea that an anti-hero has a moral purpose beyond revenge and self-advancement
- Iago's cleverness and wit elsewhere in the play
- the extent of Iago's villainous acts and apparent motivations
- the use of 'skills', 'likeable', 'anti-hero', 'hateful', 'villain' in the given view
- anti-hero and villain as dramatic tropes
- dramatic form
- the tragedy/domestic tragedy genre
- the possible impact of particular production(s) on the interpretation of the question
- etc.

AO4 Explore connections across literary texts

Focus might be on:

- representations of attitudes to love
- representations of male friendship
- representations of dissembling
- representations of women as less powerful and less secure in their social/relationship role
- representations of relationships between men and women
- representations of love relationships
- the expectations of men in authority and in marriage
- the expectations of women
- the effect of third parties and duplicity in relationships
- the tragedy/domestic tragedy genre
- etc.

AO3 Demonstrate understanding of the significance and influence of the contexts in which literary texts are written and received

Focus might be on:

- how expectations of friendship and love relationships might have changed over time
- how expectations of men in positions of power/responsibility might have changed over time
- how attitudes to morality might have changed over time
- how attitudes to men's and women's roles might have changed over time
- this scene in the context of a stage-managed process orchestrated by Iago to undermine the relationship between Othello and Desdemona and to frame Roderigo, Cassio, Bianca, Desdemona and Othello
- attitudes towards love and women expressed in the play
- the dramatic form
- the tragedy/domestic tragedy genre
- etc.

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AO2 Analyse ways in which meanings are shaped in literary texts

Focus might be on:

- structural issues relating to this stage of the plot and the relationships so far established between characters
- the ways in which verse form reflects the feelings of the speakers
- the use of irony and dramatic irony
- explicit references to love
- the use of military titles of rank
- Shakespeare's use of prose vs poetry in this exchange
- the use of listing to describe Desdemona and Othello's actions and qualities
- imagery of construction
- imagery of religion
- Cassio's relative passivity
- the shift in tone and focus during the soliloquy
- the use of antonyms
- how Iago expresses his final vow to destroy them all
- the ways in which statements, exclamations, questions and commands are used to define relationships and build arguments
- dramatic form – tragedy/domestic tragedy
- possible stage effects and interpretations
- etc.

AO1 Articulate informed, personal and creative responses to literary texts, using associated concepts and terminology, and coherent, accurate written expression

- quality of argument
- organisation of ideas
- use of appropriate concepts and terminology
- technical accuracy.

Accept any valid interpretations, any valid comments on contexts and any valid discussion of authorial methods.

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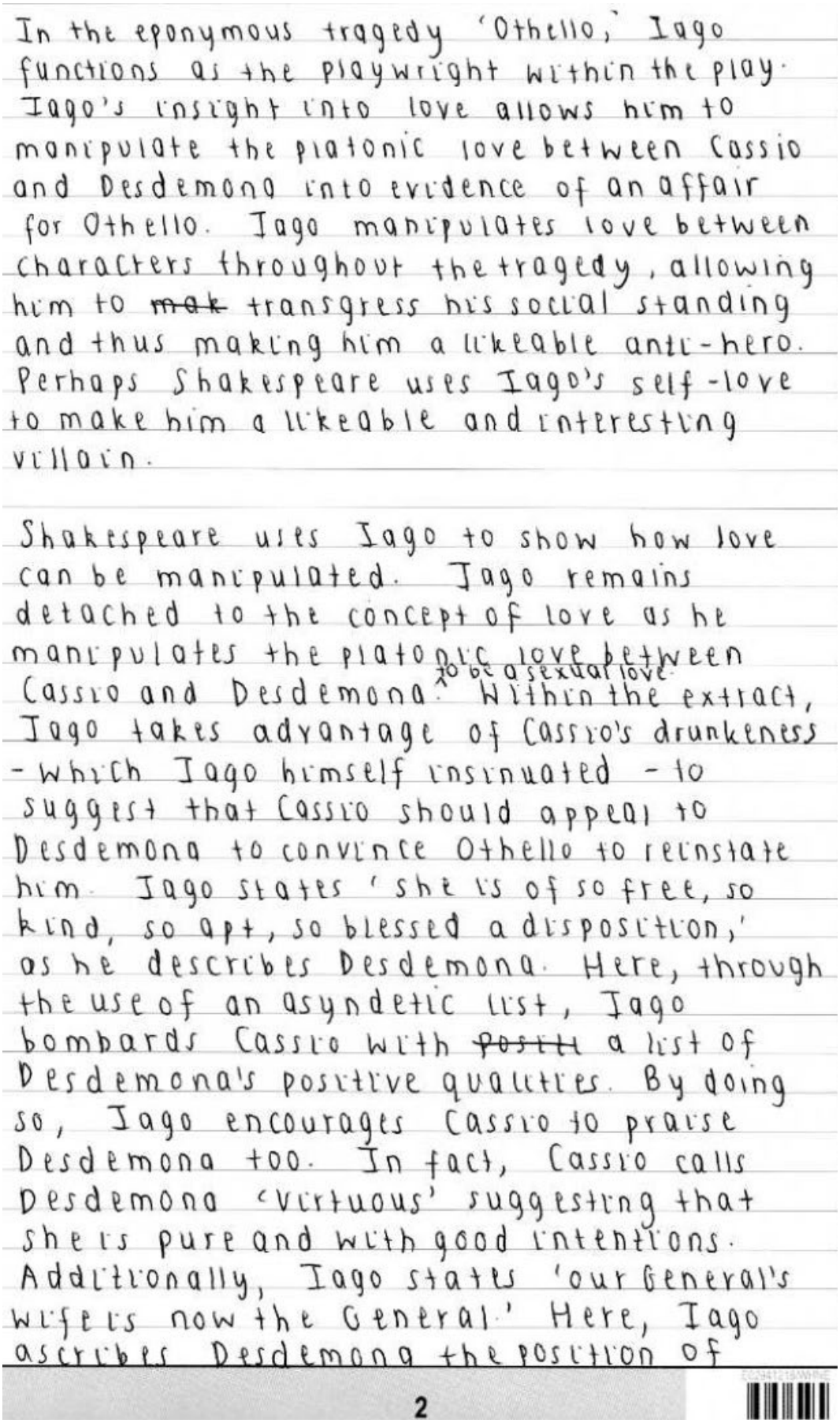
Student responses to mark

Student A



In the eponymous tragedy 'Othello,' Iago functions as the playwright within the play. Iago's insight into love allows him to manipulate the platonic love between Cassio and Desdemona into evidence of an affair for Othello. Iago manipulates love between characters throughout the tragedy, allowing him to ~~mak~~ transgress his social standing and thus making him a likeable anti-hero. Perhaps Shakespeare uses Iago's self-love to make him a likeable and interesting villain.

Shakespeare uses Iago to show how love can be manipulated. Iago remains detached to the concept of love as he manipulates the platonic love between Cassio and Desdemona (to be a sexual love). Within the extract, Iago takes advantage of Cassio's drunkeness - which Iago himself insinuated - to suggest that Cassio should appeal to Desdemona to convince Othello to reinstate him. Iago states 'she is of so free, so kind, so apt, so blessed a disposition,' as he describes Desdemona. Here, through the use of an asyndetic list, Iago bombards Cassio with ~~positi~~ a list of Desdemona's positive qualities. By doing so, Iago encourages Cassio to praise Desdemona too. In fact, Cassio calls Desdemona 'virtuous' suggesting that she is pure and with good intentions. Additionally, Iago states 'our General's wife is now the General.' Here, Iago ascribes Desdemona the position of

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a 'General' which gives her a level of power that would be considered unnatural for a woman in a patriarchal society. However, Iago uses this to cleverly echo Cassio's words earlier in the play, demonstrating his skills. When Desdemona arrives in Cyprus - a setting to symbolise chaos and disorder - Cassio cries 'our great captain's captain.' With this, Cassio elevates Desdemona's status to be above Othello. Cassio also states 'let her have your knees.' Here, this places Cassio in a submissive pose as if he is worshipping Desdemona, drawing on chilvaric codes of devotion that were popular in the Renaissance era. Iago, who is present at the time, recognises the ability to manipulate Cassio's courteous language to be evidence of a sexual affair with Desdemona in Othello's eyes. In this way, Shakespeare uses Iago's detached attitude towards love to make him an unusual villain. Iago's skills to manipulate characters makes him a likeable antihero over the course of the tragedy.

Shakespeare constructs Iago to have an insight into human nature - he understands that love ~~is~~ for someone is often a love for what they provide. Within the extract, Iago states '[Othello's] soul is so enfettered to her love.' Here, Shakespeare uses asides as a dramatic technique to explore

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the inner workings of the mind. Through this, Iago suggests that Othello is completely devoted to Desdemona. Additionally, 'enfettered' suggests that he is completely captivated by Desdemona. Iago continues, 'that she may make, unmake, do what she list.' Here, this asyndetic list shows that Iago believes Desdemona can instruct Othello. The imperative verbs 'make' and 'unmake' suggests that Iago believes Desdemona has authority over Othello in their relationship. Perhaps this notion is due to Iago's knowledge of Othello's position in society - as a black man, Desdemona gives Othello a chance to be seen as normative. In fact, first performed in 1604, a white actor with black face paint performed the role of Othello, truly capturing the liminal position of black people in Jacobean society. This unique insight into love that Iago harbours can also be seen in the wider play when Iago appeals to Brabantio about Desdemona's marriage. Iago recognises Brabantio's possessive streal as a patriarch - his love for Desdemona is to control her. Iago cries, 'thieves, thieves.' Here, the use of episeuxis is used to alarm and overwhelm Brabantio. Additionally, the monosyllabic language is simplistic but allows Iago to capture Brabantio's attention. Bubb argues that Iago has 'a facility with language' which

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can clearly be seen in this scene. Iago continues to state 'look to your house, your daughter and your bags.' Here, Iago embeds Desdemona within a list of materialistic items to suggest that Brabantio views her as a commodity. Although Brabantio begins this scene 'above' Iago, he ends up on the same level as Iago as he descends into Iago's metaphorical web of lies. Therefore, Iago's skills with language and understanding of love allow him to ~~transgr~~ transgress his inferior social standing. With this, Shakespeare to a modern audience makes Iago a likeable anti-hero as the audience become complicit in his plan through asides and root for him to succeed as he challenges the social structure.

Perhaps what makes Iago an especially likeable antihero is the self-love he harbours. Shakespeare uses Iago to show the power of an individual who has a strong sense of self. Within the extract, Iago states 'I play the villain.' Here, we see Iago assume the role of the villain himself - he casts himself as the puppet master within the play. This demonstrates a level of self-awareness to Iago's character, which can be considered unusual when compared to other ~~villians~~ villains. Iago continues to revel in his plan, stating 'divinity of hell!'

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This association with 'hell' aligns Iago with evil, thus communicating his villainy to the audience. Additionally, the exclamation suggests Iago's pleasure in this – his pleasure in assuming the role of the villain. Through this, Shakespeare shows Iago's strong sense of self and the love he has for himself. This notion of self love is established from the outset of the play. In the opening scene, Iago confesses that he hates Othello because 'it is thought abroad that 'twixt my sheets his done my office.' Here, this euphemism suggests that Othello has had an affair with his wife, suggesting that Iago's love for his wife is motivating his revenge. However, later, Iago claims that he loves Desdemona. Unlike Cinthio's 'Hecatommithi' in which Iago really does love Desdemona, Shakespeare suggests that Iago's love is born out of a desire for revenge as he soon reduces it to his own 'peculiar end.' Iago's lack of a fixed motivation makes him a three-dimensional, unusual and therefore, likeable villain. In fact, Iago only admits that he 'follows [Othello] to serve [his] turn ~~up~~ upon him.' With this, Shakespeare presents Iago as a Machiavellian villain, who seeks to fulfill his own selfish desires. This discredits Dutton's argument that Iago 'is as much a tragic figure as any one of

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Shakespeare's protagonists' as it shows the self-love he has for himself. With this, Shakespeare uses Iago's self love and strong sense of self to make him a likeable rather than hateful villain.

Typically, in love literature, the lovers are doomed from the beginning. Shakespeare uses Iago to follow this typicality. However, Shakespeare breaks the typicality of love literature by encouraging the audience to root for Iago rather than Othello and Desdemona. Written in the Renaissance era and reflecting the increasing interest in the potential of the individual, Shakespeare uses Iago to suggest that self-love is crucial to navigate the ~~world~~. external forces of the world.

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Student B

In Othello, Shakespeare presents Iagos attitude to love often through his actions of destruction, for example his manipulation towards Othello could emphasise his love for Emilia as her affair with Othello may be motive for his vengance. However his actions may show the opposite as it could be implied that Iago wants to destroy love, suggesting a hatred towards it. It could also be said that the homosocial relationship between Iago and Othello could show attitude to love as Iago cares for Othello.

In the extract, Iago speaks of his plans to destroy the love between ~~Desd~~ Desdemona and Othello, "his soul is so enfettered to her love... even as her appetite shall play the God with his weak function" The implication of Desdemonas 'appetite' was a social norm in Venecian society as females would often be promiscuous, this could show Iagos attitude towards love as he wants to poison Othello against Desdemona, "I'll pour this pestilence into his ear" suggests the idea of Iago being a ~~puppe~~ puppet master in Othellos relationship: Critic notes, O'toole suggests 'Iago is a Machiavellian villain' this could show his attitude towards love as throughout the course of the play Iago manipulates Othello to turn against desdemona, this may contrast the view given as the ~~contrast~~ Iagos hateful attitude towards love and Othellos

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relationship could imply him to be a hateful villain rather than a likeable anti-hero.

However, Iagos motive for vengance on Othello may show a positive attitude towards love. The ~~suggesting~~ accusation of Othello having an affair with Iagos wife, Emilia, may be motive for Iagos destruction of love, this may cause the primary effect on the audience as they ~~may~~ may feel sympathy towards Iago, this could suggest him to be a 'likable anti-hero'. "I am not what I am" ~~the~~ the dramatic irony used ~~in~~ here could reinforce the sympathy from the audience toward Iago, as it is already known he does not mean what he says, this could make his character seem more honest and likeable. furthermore, Iagos allusations against Othello "Twixt my sheets" may strengthen the audiences feeling of empathy toward Iago as his vengance has motive. This could also show Iagos attitude to love as he seeks to destroy Othello for destroying his own love, implying his love for his own wife, ~~Iago~~ Emilia, was strong. This contrastingly shows Iagos positive attitude towards love as he seeks vengance for the loss of his own love through his manipulation of Othello.

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Moreover, it could be suggested that the relationship between Iago and Othello could show attitudes towards love, in Venetian society, homosocial relationships were seen as higher value than love and private relationships this could controversially show Iagos attitude towards love as critic Smith suggests 'Iago is a repressed homosexual' this could be reinforced through his skills in the play as his plans to destroy love may be out of jealousy. "Beware my Lord, for it is the green eyed monster which doth Mock the meat it feeds on" this could imply Iagos own emotions as he describes jealousy from his own point of view, this could further emphasise the critic ideas as well as developing the primacy effect, making the audience feel more Sympathetic towards Iago as his destruction of love has a 'likeable' motive.

However this may not be Iagos attitude towards love as he 'puppet masters' the destruction of love "even now, now, very now the old black ram is tupping your white ewe" Iagos use of 'now now, very now" creates an immediate effect, suggesting that whatever he is implying is happening. This may help emphasise what he is

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saying as the listener may become more aware due to the repetition of the present tense, making his language more effective. The manipulation of Brabantio could further show Iagos hatred for love as he wants to destroy Othello and Desdemona along with their love, he does this by manipulating others that may also have an impact on their relationship.

In light of this I disagree with the view as I think Shakespeare has successfully presented Iago as a hateful villian with a negative attitude towards love. This is because throughout the play he becomes a puppet master to make sure he is successful in his plan to destroy love, furher reinforcing his hatred for love.

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Student C

In Shakespeares play 'Othello' Shakespeare presents Iago as more of a likable anti-hero in comparison to a villain.

The representation of Iago throughout the play often subverts the usual representation of the villainous character in most of Shakespeares plays. The reason Iago could be depicted as ~~or~~ an anti-hero and not a villain, is due to the fact that Iago never physically causes harm to a character, and indeed uses the power of deception to get the other characters (who trust him) to be manipulated into doing the acts of a villain instead of Iago doing it for himself.

A key point in the play when Iago is clearly shown manipulating those who trust him is when he convinces Roderigo to ~~murder~~ commit a murder on his own benefit. This murder ~~took place after the party~~ attempt, took place after the party and Roderigo only did it in the hope that it would destroy the competition he had for Desdemonas love. ~~and~~ However this was all part of Iagos plan to get closer to Othello and begin to manipulate him too. This scene clearly shows Iago as a likable anti-hero in comparisson to a ~~hero~~ villain as due to everyones honest trust in him, he is able to manipulate others and do villainous acts without others realising they all lead back to him.

In the extract, Iagos ~~manipulate~~ friendly manipulation can be seen from the very beginning. During Act 2, Scene 3 Iagos goal is to get Cassio intoxicated at Othellos party in hope that he

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will begin a fight or any type of reckless behaviour that may cost him his role in the pieces. Iago is able to manipulate Cassio into drinking more by using words like "good lieutenant" and "love honest and kindness" to entice Cassio and pressure him into drinking more. Iago also personifies the wine by stating "good wine is a good familiar creature" adding emphasis that the wine is harmless and safe, meaning Cassio would relax and drink more, again corresponding to Iagos manipulative plan.

During the entirety of the play, the audience are exposed to Iagos plan quite early on. During Iagos monologue, he often repeates the words "I am not what I am" again linking to this idea of Iago being likeable and more of an anti-hero instead of a villain. Throughout the play, Iago is often described and raised to as 'honest Iago' and this quote mirrors the idea of Iago not being who the people claim and believe him to be. This oxymoron is given to the audience quite early in the play to allow them to understand more on what Iagos character is really like, and be more aware of the plot than the characters within the play, drawing in the audience as they want the characters to find out Iagos character is an oxymoron and is not as kind and honest as they may believe him to be.

In the extract, Iago states "I play the villain when this advice is free, I give" Shakespeare has done this to

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show Iago undermining himself and to make Cassio feel empathetically towards him. This is a clear example of Iago misleading the other characters, and portraying himself as a friendly face and as someone who is innocent when the audience are made to be aware that this isn't the case. This portrays Iago as a likable and relatable person to the other characters, meaning his plans of manipulation will fall into place, however, to the audience this portrays him as an anti-hero as even though he doesn't do anything physically wrong he is still trying to cause harm.

Overall, in the play 'Othello' by William Shakespeare Iagos skills of manipulation ~~are~~ made his character vastly respected and liked by other characters, and to both a modern audience and a Shakespearean audience, Iago's character could be depicted as more of an anti-hero over villain as he never did anything physically wrong, he just abused others trust in him and made them do it for him by convincing them it was for their own benefit and that he was helping them.

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Question 14 Paper 2A, June 2024

'In *Regeneration*, Barker suggests there is no escape from war.'

Examine this view of the novel.

[25 marks]

Mark scheme

It is important to remember that these students, in the main, are 18 years old so we are judging their skills at the end of Key Stage 5.

Weightings for each question are as follows:

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	AO4	• perceptive exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• perceptive understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • assuredness in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• perceptive understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • assured engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• perceptive, assured and sophisticated argument in relation to the task • assured use of literary critical concepts and terminology; mature and impressive expression	

Band 4 **Coherent/Thorough** **16–20 marks** '**Coherence**' is shown when students are logical and consistent in their arguments in relation to the task. They hold their ideas together in an intelligible way. '**Thoroughness**' is shown when students write carefully, precisely and accurately.	AO5	• thorough engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **coherent** and **thorough** work where ideas are linked together in a focused and purposeful way in relation to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a fully **coherent** and **thorough** argument across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band ideas will be discussed in a shaped, relevant and purposeful way with a clear sense of direction, with one or two lapses in **coherence** and accuracy.
	AO4	• logical and consistent exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• thorough understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • coherence in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• thorough understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • thorough engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• logical, thorough and coherent argument in relation to the task where ideas are debated in depth • appropriate use of literary critical concepts and terminology; precise and accurate expression	

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Band 3 **Straightforward/ Relevant** **11–15 marks** '**Straightforward**' work is shown when students make their ideas in relation to the task clearly known. '**Relevant**' work is shown when students are focused on the task and use detail in an appropriate and supportive way.	AO5	• straightforward engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **straightforward** and **relevant** work where the student's response to the task is clear and intelligible. At the top of the band students will demonstrate consistent **straightforward** understanding in the course of their argument. Ideas will be developed **relevantly**. At the bottom of the band there will be flashes of **relevant** understanding with evidence of **straightforward** thinking.
	AO4	• explores connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study in a straightforward way	
	AO3	• straightforward understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • relevant connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• straightforward understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • relevant engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• sensibly ordered ideas in a relevant argument in relation to the task • some use of literary critical concepts and terminology which are mainly appropriate; straightforward and clear expression	

Band 2 **Simple/Generalised** **6–10 marks** '**Simple**' work is shown when students write in an unelaborated and basic way in relation to the task. '**Generalised**' work is shown when students write without regard to particular details.	AO5	• simple and generalised response to the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **simple** and **generalised** work which is mainly linked to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a basic **generalised** understanding in the course of their answer. Ideas will be developed in a **simple** way. At the bottom of the band there will be inconsistency, but the beginnings of a **simple** and **generalised** understanding.
	AO4	• simple exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• simple understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • generalised connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• simple understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • generalised engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• a simple structure to the argument which may not be consistent but which does relate to the task • generalised use of literary critical concepts and terminology; simple expression	

Band 1 **Largely irrelevant/largely misunderstood/largely inaccurate** **1–5 marks** '**Largely irrelevant**' work is shown when students write in an unclear way with only occasional reference to what is required by the question. '**Largely misunderstood**' and '**largely inaccurate**' work is shown when knowledge of the text is insecure, hazy and often wrong.		• some vague points in relation to the task and some ideas about task and text(s) • the writing is likely to be unclear and incorrect; if it is accurate the content will be irrelevant • little sense of the AOs in relation to the task; little sense of how meanings are shaped; little sense of any relevant contexts; little sense of any connection arising out of historicist study; little sense of an argument in relation to the task	This band is characterised by work which is **largely irrelevant** and **largely misunderstood** and **largely inaccurate**, and so unlikely to be addressing the AOs in a relevant way. At the top of the band students will mention some unconnected points in relation to the task during the course of their writing. The writing is likely to lack clarity. At the bottom of the band there will be no connection with the task; the writing will be hard to follow and **irrelevant**.
0 marks		No marks for response when nothing is written or where response has no connection to the text(s) or task.	

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Possible content:

Please refer to pages 4 to 7.

AO5 Explore literary texts informed by different interpretations

Students might consider:

- different interpretations of 'escape'
- how characters such as Burns and Prior project their war experiences on to their surroundings
- Prior's treatment requires him to relive his front line experiences
- Sassoon's experience of nightmares and hallucinations of war when he is away from the front line
- Sassoon's protest against home front attitudes that prolong the war
- how the home front setting allows a female perspective on war; for example, Sarah Lumb has been affected by the war through bereavement and her work in a munitions factory
- Rivers' experience of a church service in Chapter 14 and how the war has given new significance to the biblical story of Abraham and Isaac
- the home front experience of war through the air raids that Rivers experiences in Chapter 20
- the significance of a geographical separation from the front line
- the extent to which Prior's relationship with Sarah is an escape from war
- how memories and dreams are significant and present an escape from war
- the significance of Prior's escape from front line duty
- etc.

AO4 Explore connections across literary texts

Focus might be on:

- prose representations of the lasting nature of soldiers' suffering
- prose representations of hospitals, doctors, and trauma patients in the literature of World War 1 and its aftermath
- prose representations of soldiers away from the front line
- the differing representations of home front settings and attitudes
- the impact of war on women
- etc.

AO3 Demonstrate understanding of the significance and influence of the contexts in which literary texts are written and received

Focus might be on:

- the female perspective of the writer in her presentation of masculinity and trauma
- changing attitudes to the effect of war on society through an awareness of the long-term effects of war trauma on veterans and society as a whole

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- an understanding of the changing treatment of war trauma
- the use of historical research in late-twentieth century prose texts on the war
- changing presentation of the experience of soldiers away from the front line
- etc.

AO2 Analyse ways in which meanings are shaped in literary texts

Focus might be on:

- aspects of narrative form and genre such as dialogue and varying perspectives within third-person narrative
- the use of descriptive detail to show that the landscape of war is echoed in home front settings; for example the presentation of Aldeburgh in Chapter 15
- the extent to which Barker uses Rivers' viewpoint to show the impact of war away from the front line
- etc.

AO1 Articulate informed, personal and creative responses to literary texts, using associated concepts and terminology, and coherent, accurate written expression

- quality of argument
- organisation of ideas
- use of appropriate concepts and terminology
- technical accuracy.

Accept any valid interpretations, any valid comments on contexts and any valid discussion of authorial methods.

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Student responses to mark

Student D

In Pat Barker's ~~Fiction~~ novel 'Regeneration', there is a primary focus on the permanent damage and trauma ~~the~~ war had on men literally and historically. Constructing each character's traumatic experiences in the trenches as an amalgamation of her grandfather's letters illustrates the war experience as both permanent and inescapable. Barker specifically highlights the consequences of war through the portrayals of Prior and Burns, arguably the most impacted individuals in the novel.

David Burns is portrayed as a kind, innocent man and a symbol of all the lost potential for academic young men who instead were forced to join the war effort. In the novel, his trauma is manifested by the impossibility of eating as he eventually throws it back up and is described as a 'skin ... alimentary canal.' Chapter four particularly highlights the residual effects of Burns' trauma as he performs a mock funeral ritual with ... animals. Barker describes 'He felt ... separated him', expressing Burn's conflicting emotions and mental breakdown. The preposition of 'beside' suggests Burns views himself as similar to the dead animals, highlighting how soldiers were perceived as barbaric animals especially from their own perspective as they struggle to understand their own capacity to kill. The symbolism of 'clothes ... them' emphasises how Burns views himself as ~~dec~~ diseased and on the verge of death, and the only true thing separating soldiers from predators of the wild is an army uniform. In society during the war, the uniform represented both the monarch and God's duty however in this chapter Burns alludes to the uniform acting as a facade.

Barker's construction of characters emphasises the long-standing emotional consequences of war and how the trauma may manifest in debilitating ways. Unlike Burns's trauma which manifested as the inability to eat, Prior's trauma is presented as muteness for the first portion of the novel. In chapter nine, Barker illustrates the initial cause of mutism. In

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Prior. AO an officer in the army, Prior was entrusted to clean up trenches regularly however in this particular event his emotions are unable to be repressed despite the patriarchal expectations of the time - Prior exclaims when he discovers an eye 'what am ... grub-stopper?'. The irony of the metaphor 'grub stopper' is crucial as this traumatic association of the eye is physically what stops Prior from speaking which has the same effect as a 'grub stopper.' Prior's casual tone is also influential as he diminishes the significance and horror of finding an eye through litotes and humour when in reality the discovery sent him to Craiglockhart to be treated.

However some critics argue that Barker is incapable of truly communicating the tragedies and impact of war and despite having access to her grandfather's entries she couldn't properly convey the emotions of the men and her opinions on whether war is ever capable or not were not credible. This notion is specifically supported by trauma theorist Cathy Caruth who claimed 'trauma stand ... representation'. This diminishes the credibility of Barker's novel as a representation of men's mental health post war and suggests she is unable to write a true account of the mental consequences.

Following the discovery of the eyeball, Prior's true effects of autism and how much of a hindrance the condition has had on him becomes clear. He described 'a sense ... elation almost' when discovering observing the men's ability to speak something he can no longer do as a result of the war despite leaving the trenches. The oxymoron of 'joy' and 'elation' emphasises his dismay at the effects of the war and his longing to speak again so he's able to join his men. The epanalepsis suggests Prior had such admiration for what general society would consider minor things as it has been taken away from her. Another novel where the effects of war on men ~~is clear post war~~ as a

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result of the war is discussed in Sebastian Faulk's novel 'Birdsong'. The primary protagonist Jack Firebrace exclaims in a sense of desperation 'this is ...

be degraded'. The monosyllabic phrasing of 'this ... a war' highlights Jack's adamancy that men are being taken advantage of as soldiers and more care should be taken regarding soldier's mental health as the effects may permanent ~~similar~~ an example of which is Burns who is unable to recover in the duration of the novel.

To conclude, Barker's novel 'Regeneration' as a work of fiction highlights the significant impact on mental health and young officers at the time whose trauma were manifested as both mental and physical conditions. Her characterisation of Burns and Prior shows the spectrum of recovery for soldiers at the time as Prior was able to speak by the end of the novel whereas Burns made little progress suggesting that for some there is no escape from war.

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Question 11 Paper 2B, June 2024

Explore the significance of loneliness and social isolation in this extract.

Remember to include in your answer relevant detailed analysis of the ways that Aldridge shapes meanings.

[25 marks]

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Extract from *A Trick I Learned from Dead Men* by Kitty Aldridge, published in 2012

In the afternoon the lovely Lorelle drops off the sympathy blooms from Fleurtations. I toss away my yoghurt and hurry out when I see the van.

Hey, I say.

Hey, Lee, she says. All right?

Lorelle: One of life's optimists, always smiling. Possibly from working with flowers or she could've just been born like it. Happy as Larry, Derek calls her. Lorelle experiences the peaks and troughs of life, whereas here we're a lot more skewed being that we are merely death death death twenty-four seven.

It's not just her happy-go-luckiness, I like the gap between her front teeth, the freckle under her right eye, the way her brown eyes slant down. She has a piece of hair that collapses now and then over her face. She tucks it behind her ear. I put my hands in my pockets to stop me tucking it for her and getting done for harassment.

The phrase, dazzling smile, was made for Lorelle. Talk about knock you down, her smile could send you through a hedge. From her perspective life looks like one mad raving bender of birth, baptism, marriage, death. All the big dates in a human life. P'raps her view is as skewed as mine after all. Nice to have things in common. Saying that, we don't just natter about work. If I bring a brew from the office we discuss varied topics. Or sometimes we just stand with our tea, thinking on.

She has no flaws as far as I can tell other than when she parks the van she mounts the kerb but, I think to myself, So what? She could have her pick of men so I'm not taking anything for granted. I haven't asked her out yet. I don't want to frighten her off. Nice and easy. Tiptoe through the tulips.

What d'you call that? Derek is referring to Mrs Whitmarsh. I have finished Mrs Whitmarsh and reckoned her to look good for someone who is dead.

She looks grey, says Derek. She looks ill, son. Get some colour on her before the resus team arrive.

Despite Derek's superiority I do not take this lying down.

I was going for a natural look, I say.

Well, you've overdone it. She looks terrible, he says. Dear God. No one wants to see their relative looking dead, Lee. They want to see the face they loved back when, OK? An approximation of the good old days, Christmas morning after a nip of sherry. That's the look you're after, he says. Are you with me?

Yes, I say.

Derek smooths back his hair, fastens his waistcoat, turns on the tap to wash his hands. No good them going out looking worse than when they came in, he says. Get some sherry down her, glad tidings to all men, get some peace on earth. And get a move on.

Of all Derek's foibles, having the last word, to my mind, is the most grating.

*

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I like to walk the long way. Blow the cobwebs. I forget about them afterwards, I don't take my work home. I like the wind pushing down Bursthill Lane from Cinder Hill, blows their old selves off me. Wind takes them, the deceased clients, off they go. I get the taste of the woods in my mouth and my legs know where to roam.

Welcome to Our Historic Village, it says on the sign.

OK, cheers!

There is a bird by the public footpath who whistles like a human, every day the same, like he's doing someone's windows with a bucket of suds. No sight of him, but still. I know he's there.

Buonasera, I say. He stops whistling for a moment.

I look for Crow. He waits on the telegraph wire by the postbox. He tilts his shiny eye.

Late again, Lee. You'll be late for your own funeral.

Such wit from a carrion bird.

You got nothing to crow about, I say.

That round goes to me, I reckon. Laters, Mr Corvid.*

*

I always slam the door when I come in. I could just say, Hello, but only one of them would hear and neither would reply. I could say, I'm home! But what would it achieve?

First thing I see is the dirty dish stack, frying pan on top, upturned like a sombrero. Buenos dias.

The best view in the house is from the sink. I wash the dishes, watch the sun drop into the woods, pyrotechnics. The house makes a giant shadow of itself on the lane. I hang the tea towel on the cupboard door.

Lester has a beard. A result of his TV marathon. He has watched TV non-stop since she died. If you measured his beard you could p'raps even get the date she passed. Possible Les has broken a round-the-clock TV-watching record and none of us know it.

Reality TV is Lester's reality. He won't watch a quiz, game show or drama. The only good news is no news, he says.

What d'you want for dinner, baked potato or omelette?

No answer. Lately he doesn't reply. Gets on my nerves. Deaf is a political party in this house. Lester is tired of news since receiving the worst news he could have imagined. His plan now is to receive no news whatsoever, not even TV or radio. Easy to knock it, but. Seems to work for him. Just the job, as he would have once said.

I do omelette. I add peas and mushroom. Les has his with the reality people. Ned and me have ours with each other. Ned stirs his tea on and on, ting-a-ling. Jesus. Does your head.

**Mr Corvid is a nickname derived from 'corvidae', the Latin name for the bird family that includes the crow.*

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Mark scheme

It is important to remember that these students, in the main, are 18 years old so we are judging their skills at the end of Key Stage 5.

Weightings for each question are as follows:

AO1: 7 marks AO2: 6 marks AO3: 6 marks AO4: 3 marks AO5: 3 marks.

Mark	AO	Typical features	How to arrive at mark
Band 5 **Perceptive/Assured** **21–25 marks** '**Perception**' is demonstrated when students are showing the depth of their understanding and responding sensitively to the texts and task. '**Assuredness**' is shown when students write with confidence and conviction.	AO5	• perceptive and confident engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **perceptive** and **assured** work which shows confidence, sharpness of mind and sophistication in relation to the task. At the top of the band students are consistently **assured** and will demonstrate sensitivity and **perception** across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band there will be coherence and accuracy with some **perception** but with less consistency and evenness.
	AO4	• perceptive exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• perceptive understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • assuredness in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• perceptive understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • assured engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• perceptive, assured and sophisticated argument in relation to the task • assured use of literary critical concepts and terminology; mature and impressive expression	
Band 4 **Coherent/Thorough** **16–20 marks** '**Coherence**' is shown when students are logical and consistent in their arguments in relation to the task. They hold their ideas together in an intelligible way. '**Thoroughness**' is shown when students write carefully, precisely and accurately.	AO5	• thorough engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **coherent** and **thorough** work where ideas are linked together in a focused and purposeful way in relation to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a fully **coherent** and **thorough** argument across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band ideas will be discussed in a shaped, relevant and purposeful way with a clear sense of direction, with one or two lapses in **coherence** and accuracy.
	AO4	• logical and consistent exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• thorough understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • coherence in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• thorough understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • thorough engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• logical, thorough and coherent argument in relation to the task where ideas are debated in depth • appropriate use of literary critical concepts and terminology; precise and accurate expression	
Band 3 **Straightforward/** **Relevant** **11–15 marks** '**Straightforward**' work is shown when students make their ideas in relation to the task clearly known. '**Relevant**' work is shown when students are focused on the task and use detail in an appropriate and supportive way.	AO5	• straightforward engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **straightforward** and **relevant** work where the student's response to the task is clear and intelligible. At the top of the band students will demonstrate consistent **straightforward** understanding in the course of their argument. Ideas will be developed **relevantly**. At the bottom of the band there will be flashes of **relevant** understanding with evidence of **straightforward** thinking.
	AO4	• explores connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study in a straightforward way	
	AO3	• straightforward understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • relevant connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• straightforward understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • relevant engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• sensibly ordered ideas in a relevant argument in relation to the task • some use of literary critical concepts and terminology which are mainly appropriate; straightforward and clear expression	
Band 2 **Simple/Generalised** **6–10 marks** '**Simple**' work is shown when students write in an unelaborated and basic way in relation to the task. '**Generalised**' work is shown when students write without regard to particular details.	AO5	• simple and generalised response to the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **simple** and **generalised** work which is mainly linked to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a basic **generalised** understanding in the course of their answer. Ideas will be developed in a **simple** way. At the bottom of the band there will be inconsistency, but the beginnings of a **simple** and **generalised** understanding.
	AO4	• simple exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• simple understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • generalised connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• simple understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • generalised engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• a simple structure to the argument which may not be consistent but which does relate to the task • generalised use of literary critical concepts and terminology; simple expression	

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Band 1 **Largely irrelevant/largely misunderstood/largely inaccurate** **1–5 marks** '**Largely irrelevant**' work is shown when students write in an unclear way with only occasional reference to what is required by the question. '**Largely misunderstood**' and '**largely inaccurate**' work is shown when knowledge of the text is insecure, hazy and often wrong.		• some vague points in relation to the task and some ideas about task and text(s) • the writing is likely to be unclear and incorrect; if it is accurate the content will be irrelevant • little sense of the AOs in relation to the task; little sense of how meanings are shaped; little sense of any relevant contexts; little sense of any connection arising out of historicist study; little sense of an argument in relation to the task	This band is characterised by work which is **largely irrelevant** and **largely misunderstood** and **largely inaccurate**, and so unlikely to be addressing the AOs in a relevant way. At the top of the band students will mention some unconnected points in relation to the task during the course of their writing. The writing is likely to lack clarity. At the bottom of the band there will be no connection with the task; the writing will be hard to follow and **irrelevant**.
0 marks		No marks for response when nothing is written or where response has no connection to the text(s) or task.	

AO5 Explore literary texts informed by different interpretations

Focus might be on:

- how the three different settings – funeral parlour, countryside, home – all contribute to the sense of loneliness and isolation within the extract, as well as situating the extract very clearly post-2000 in the Modern Times synchronic time period
- issues of gender, power and class, given Aldridge's presentation of Lee as an interesting and unusual character who, despite his apparent cheerfulness, seems to live a lonely and isolated life for a young man in his mid-twenties
- how Lee's unusual job and difficult home life contribute to his loneliness and isolation
- the loneliness and grief associated with the idea of death possibly being mitigated by Lee's interest in his work, the constant presence of Derek (however annoying) and the visit from Lorelle
- the possibility that Lee and Lorelle may develop a relationship that could assuage his loneliness
- the fact that Lee is surrounded by the lonely and grief-stricken – from the relatives of the dead he works with professionally, to the personal grief caused by the death of his mother, which seems to have left Lee as the carer for Ned, who is isolated by his deafness, and Lester, who has withdrawn from the real world in favour of watching television
- the pathos of Lee's imagined conversations with the crow and view of the countryside from the kitchen sink in their isolated cottage suggesting he wants to connect with others and escape his isolation
- etc.

AO4 Explore connections across literary texts

Focus might be on:

- representations of loneliness and social isolation, for example as caused by aspects of society, culture, gender, race, nationality, disability, sexuality, religion or class, as seen in modern literature
- etc.

AO3 Demonstrate understanding of the significance and influence of the contexts in which literary texts are written and received

Focus might be on:

- ideas about how various representations of loneliness and social isolation, and their possible causes, may be seen to have an impact upon the ways in which issues key to the context of Modern Times, such as class, gender, race, culture, sexuality and national identity are received and understood
- etc.

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AO2 Analyse ways in which meanings are shaped in literary texts

Focus might be on:

- Aldridge's decision to use a young man to represent ideas about loneliness and social isolation
- the use of a first-person narrative stance; the possible mix of pathos and humour in Lee's idiosyncratic voice and matter-of-fact descriptions of aspects of his unusual working life and rather sad home circumstances
- Lee's initial apparent cheerfulness and lively interest in things and other people may initially make him an atypical lonely or socially-isolated character, although this seems to change as the extract continues
- that Lee spends all day working with dead people, which he seems to accept calmly; being interrupted by the annoying Derek is clearly no antidote to loneliness or social isolation
- the pathos of Lee's dreams of a relationship with Lorelle, who seems positive, optimistic and full of life; Lee's obvious attraction to her and the seeming unlikeliness of them forming a relationship; the tragi-comic irony of the name of Lorelle's floristry business – 'Fleurtations'
- the three-part structure and the various relationships presented
- Aldridge's use of Lee's stepfather, Lester, to represent chronic loneliness and social isolation; the irony of his refusal to communicate with anyone but the 'reality people' on television, who are unlikely to be very 'real' at all, but edited media constructs
- Lee's imaginative and unusual interior monologue, including his conversations with the crow, which seem partly to compensate for the silence of Lester, who is obviously seriously depressed, and Ned, who is deaf – Lee's tart observation that 'Deaf is a political party in this house'
- the use of unusual language to suggest Lee's quirky and slightly offbeat personality: colloquialisms and slang phrases that may seem quaint or old-fashioned 'Tiptoe through the tulips'; the use of foreign greetings such as 'Buonasera' and 'Buenos dias' possibly suggesting a wish to travel and connect with others to avoid loneliness and social isolation
- Lee's close observations of the other characters possibly suggesting a desire to connect with others; his self-analysis and observations of nature; the pathos of his view out of the kitchen window at home when washing up alone
- how Aldridge's word choices and syntax within the narrative description suggests the cultural context of the post-2000 era – eg the use of verisimilitude in the references to 'reality' TV
- etc.

AO1 Articulate informed, personal and creative responses to literary texts, using associated concepts and terminology, and coherent, accurate written expression

- quality of argument
- organisation of ideas
- use of appropriate concepts and terminology
- technical accuracy.

Accept any valid interpretations, any valid comments on contexts and any valid discussion of authorial methods.

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Student responses to mark

Student E

Section B

11 Explore the significance of loneliness and social isolation in this extract

The significance of loneliness and social isolation are presented in differing ways within this extract. Firstly, loneliness is presented in the speakers longing for a relationship with Lorelle while social isolation is presented within his home setting. Written in first person narration, it is likely that the author may have intended for the extract to potray the personal experiences of the speaker.

In his sphere of the workplace, the loneliness of the speaker is demonstrated through his longing to experience the same happiness as Lorelle. As the extract begins with a delievery of 'sympathy blooms'. The authors choice of describing the flowers as 'sympathy blooms' could serve as a metaphorical attempt to revivie the emotions of the speaker. It can be inferred that this was a nessecary action partly due to the speaker's repetivie comment 'we are merely surrounded by death death death'. Here the use of repetition links towards the speakers isolation as it reinforces that his is always around death in the workplace and at home which further synthesises the melachonic tone within the extract. However, the speaker's commentary on his relationship with Lorelle and how they tend to have 'nice things in common' limits an argument that he may be socially isolated.

Additonally, the author signifies the loneliness and social isolation within this extract through her choice of setting. This is evidenced in the description of how the speaker resides in a 'remote cottage'. Here the use of imagery is important as it serves as a key indiciaction of the speaker's social isolation from the outside world. Futhermore, the

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speakers loneliness and isolation is made further evident within his home sphere. A key example of this is through his comment 'I always slam the door when I come in, I could just say Hello... neither would reply'. Through this, the authors, authorial methods create a sympathetic atmophere for readers to engage with as we are provided with the extent of the speaker's loneliness and isoaltion. In addition to this, the speaker focuses on the impacts of grief and its contributions towards loneliness and social isolation. For instance, the speaker describes how his stepfather 'Lester has a beard a result of his TV marathon... since she died'. It can infered that the author might perhaps be intending to provide awarness on the effects of grief and how they often limit a person from function adequately. This is a key interpretation that can be made given the author was writing in 2012 where a stress continued to be placed on ensuring treatment of mental health. Moreover, the author uses varying sentences to further describe the loneliness and social isolation experienced by the speaker.

Within the first part of the extract, the speakers' narrations and sentences are potrayed as more detailed which in turn contribute towards a somewhat joyful tone. However, this is later thrawted within the second half of the extract where the speaker utlilises short sentences such as 'no answer', 'gets on my nerves' and 'i do omlette'. If we are interepreting the potenital intentions about the author to be about grieve, a possible justification of the authors varying sentences can be made that she is further attempting to create awareness on how people tend to deal with loneliness and social isoaltion caused by grief in public and in private.

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Question 5 Paper 1, June 2024

Compare and contrast the significance of ending a relationship in the following love poems.

[25 marks]

Since there's no help, come let us kiss and part

Since there's no help, come let us kiss and part –
Nay, I have done, you get no more of me;
And I am glad, yea, glad with all my heart,
That thus so cleanly I myself can free.
Shake hands for ever, cancel all our vows,
And when we meet at any time again,
Be it not seen in either of our brows
That we one jot of former love retain.
Now at the last gasp of Love's latest breath,
When, his pulse failing, Passion speechless lies,
When Faith is kneeling by his bed of death,
And Innocence is closing up his eyes,
– Now if thou would'st, when all have given him over,
From death to life thou might'st him yet recover.

Michael Drayton (1563–1631)

The Terrible Door

Too long outside your door I have shivered.
You open it? I will not stay.
I'm haunted by your ashen beauty.
Take back your hand. I have gone away.

Don't talk, but move to that near corner.
I loathe the long cold shadow here.
We will stand a moment in the lamplight,
Until I watch you hard and near.

Happy release! Good-bye for ever!
Here at the corner we say good-bye.
But if you want me, if you do need me,
Who waits, at the terrible door, but I?

Harold Monro (1879–1932)

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Mark scheme

It is important to remember that these students, in the main, are 18 years old so we are judging their skills at the end of Key Stage 5.

Weightings for each question are as follows:

AO1: 7 marks AO2: 6 marks AO3: 6 marks AO4: 3 marks AO5: 3 marks.

Mark	AO	Typical features	How to arrive at mark
Band 5 **Perceptive/Assured** **21–25 marks** '**Perception**' is demonstrated when students are showing the depth of their understanding and responding sensitively to the texts and task. '**Assuredness**' is shown when students write with confidence and conviction.	AO5	• perceptive and confident engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **perceptive** and **assured** work which shows confidence, sharpness of mind and sophistication in relation to the task. At the top of the band students are consistently **assured** and will demonstrate sensitivity and **perception** across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band there will be coherence and accuracy with some **perception** but with less consistency and evenness.
	AO4	• perceptive exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• perceptive understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • assuredness in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• perceptive understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • assured engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• perceptive, assured and sophisticated argument in relation to the task • assured use of literary critical concepts and terminology; mature and impressive expression	

Band 4 **Coherent/Thorough** **16–20 marks** '**Coherence**' is shown when students are logical and consistent in their arguments in relation to the task. They hold their ideas together in an intelligible way. '**Thoroughness**' is shown when students write carefully, precisely and accurately.	AO5	• thorough engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **coherent** and **thorough** work where ideas are linked together in a focused and purposeful way in relation to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a fully **coherent** and **thorough** argument across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band ideas will be discussed in a shaped, relevant and purposeful way with a clear sense of direction, with one or two lapses in **coherence** and accuracy.
	AO4	• logical and consistent exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• thorough understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • coherence in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• thorough understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • thorough engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• logical, thorough and coherent argument in relation to the task where ideas are debated in depth • appropriate use of literary critical concepts and terminology; precise and accurate expression	

Band 3 **Straightforward/** **Relevant** **11–15 marks** '**Straightforward**' work is shown when students make their ideas in relation to the task clearly known. '**Relevant**' work is shown when students are focused on the task and use detail in an appropriate and supportive way.	AO5	• straightforward engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **straightforward** and **relevant** work where the student's response to the task is clear and intelligible. At the top of the band students will demonstrate consistent **straightforward** understanding in the course of their argument. Ideas will be developed **relevantly**. At the bottom of the band there will be flashes of **relevant** understanding with evidence of **straightforward** thinking.
	AO4	• explores connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study in a straightforward way	
	AO3	• straightforward understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • relevant connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• straightforward understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • relevant engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• sensibly ordered ideas in a relevant argument in relation to the task • some use of literary critical concepts and terminology which are mainly appropriate; straightforward and clear expression	

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Band 2 **Simple/Generalised** **6–10 marks** '**Simple**' work is shown when students write in an unelaborated and basic way in relation to the task. '**Generalised**' work is shown when students write without regard to particular details.	AO5	• simple and generalised response to the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **simple** and **generalised** work which is mainly linked to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a basic **generalised** understanding in the course of their answer. Ideas will be developed in a **simple** way. At the bottom of the band there will be inconsistency, but the beginnings of a **simple** and **generalised** understanding.
	AO4	• simple exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• simple understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • generalised connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• simple understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • generalised engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• a simple structure to the argument which may not be consistent but which does relate to the task • generalised use of literary critical concepts and terminology; simple expression	

Band 1 **Largely irrelevant/largely misunderstood/largely inaccurate** **1–5 marks** '**Largely irrelevant**' work is shown when students write in an unclear way with only occasional reference to what is required by the question. '**Largely misunderstood**' and '**largely inaccurate**' work is shown when knowledge of the text is insecure, hazy and often wrong.		• some vague points in relation to the task and some ideas about task and text(s) • the writing is likely to be unclear and incorrect; if it is accurate the content will be irrelevant • little sense of the AOs in relation to the task; little sense of how meanings are shaped; little sense of any relevant contexts; little sense of any connection arising out of historicist study; little sense of an argument in relation to the task	This band is characterised by work which is **largely irrelevant** and **largely misunderstood** and **largely inaccurate**, and so unlikely to be addressing the AOs in a relevant way. At the top of the band students will mention some unconnected points in relation to the task during the course of their writing. The writing is likely to lack clarity. At the bottom of the band there will be no connection with the task; the writing will be hard to follow and **irrelevant**.
0 marks		No marks for response when nothing is written or where response has no connection to the text(s) or task.	

AO5 Explore literary texts informed by different interpretations

Students might consider:

- the view that Drayton's speaker is an anguished, despairing lover forced to initiate break-up because there seems to be no alternative, but then clinging on to the hope that the relationship can be revived
- the alternative view that Drayton's speaker, by use of his daring wit, is manipulating a fraught situation to seduce his lover back into the relationship
- other possible readings of Drayton's speaker and their apparent motivations
- the view that Monro's speaker is also a sincere lover forced reluctantly to end the relationship yet clinging on to hope that love may be rekindled
- the alternative view that Monro's speaker is the rejected lover, perhaps trying to assert himself and making clear his willingness to rekindle at a later date
- other possible readings of Monro's speaker and their apparent motivations
- different ways in which the title of Monro's poem might be read; 'the terrible door' perhaps representing a literal and/or symbolic barrier between the lovers
- the possible meanings of references to physical movement and gestures in both poems
- the use of 'significance' and 'ending' in the given view
- etc.

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AO4 Explore connections across literary texts

Focus might be on:

- representations of: the endings of relationships, either temporary or final; those involved; the circumstances; and the effects
- the use of narrators and their accounts of the end of a relationship
- the typicality of these poems as examples of a literary sub-genre
- the significance of settings, such as the bed and the door
- uses of the sonnet form
- Drayton's use of tropes from the Courtly Love tradition
- etc.

AO3 Demonstrate understanding of the significance and influence of the contexts in which literary texts are written and received

Focus might be on:

- the historical contexts of the poems and how attitudes to relationships and ending relationships might have changed over time
- Drayton's use of sonnet form
- Drayton's use of tropes from the Courtly Love tradition
- Monro's use of short lyric form
- poems about ending relationships as a literary sub-genre
- etc.

AO2 Analyse ways in which meanings are shaped in literary texts

Focus might be on:

- the contrasting forms of the poems: Drayton's use of the Shakespearean sonnet vs Monro's use of three lyric quatrains
- structural issues relating to the forms adopted: Drayton's use of an octave, sestet and concluding couplet to develop an elaborated argument with the volta coming in the final couplet; Monro's use of the three stanzas to describe the moment of break-up, the final glance and then the parting; Monro's use of the final two lines as the volta
- the ways in which end-stopped lines, enjambement and cesurae are used as structural devices within the poems
- ways in which verse form reflects the feelings and intentions of the narrators
- ways in which the feelings and intentions of the speakers are reflected in: word choices; different sentence types (such as the dash and final exclamation in Drayton vs the two questions and two exclamations in Monro); and rhetorical and literary devices
- ways in which the elliptical nature of poetry raises questions about the relationships in question
- Drayton's use of allegory and the death-bed conceit
- Monro's references to space and light to create atmospheric effects
- Monro's use of the door as a symbol
- the significance of Monro's title
- how the narrators use direct address to their lovers
- use of irony
- etc.

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AO1 Articulate informed, personal and creative responses to literary texts, using associated concepts and terminology, and coherent, accurate written expression

- quality of argument
- organisation of ideas
- use of appropriate concepts and terminology
- technical accuracy
- comparing texts.

Accept any valid interpretations, any valid comments on contexts and any valid discussion of authorial methods.

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Student responses to mark

Student F

Both Drayton and Monro convey the process of ending a relationship in their works. Drayton presents the helpless nature of ending a relationship out of necessity, as opposed to Monro who portrays the decision to leave a relationship and the conscious withdrawal from such a relationship.

Both poems represent the liminal space between being in a relationship and being out of one, during the brief exchange of words that supposedly bring an end to the relationship. In Drayton's 'Since there's no help, come let us kiss and part' he utilises the personification of abstract concepts to achieve this. The capitalisation of 'Love,' 'Passion', 'Faith' and 'Innocence' create an image of the concepts coming to life. Perhaps the use of personification is an attempt for the speaker to distance himself from such emotions in an attempt to conform to 16th century gender norms. As a male poet this is likely to be the case, as before the romantic era poetry-especially from male poets was emotionally limited in order to preserve the masculinity of the poet. Each personified concept is portrayed almost at the brink of death with 'pulse failing' and 'kneeling by his bed of death' as key examples of how Drayton attempts to portray the liminal space between a relationship and the absence of one by comparing it to the liminal space between life and death. In Harold Monro's The Terrible Door, the metaphor of a door is used to portray the same concept.

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The adjective 'terrible' suggests that the speaker is grieving the relationship in a morose and solemn way, but given the final stanza: "Happy release! Good-bye for ever!", One can infer that the "terrible" aspect of the severance of the relationship is the guilt felt by the speaker, which is atypical if the gender of the author is considered due to fragile masculinity; However, if one was to consider the time period of the poem, not long after the romantic era, poems were typically much more emotive, especially those concerning love and loss, such as the theme of The Terrible Door.

Furthermore the poets contrast in their views on the end of a relationship, with Drayton portraying the end of a relationship in 'since there's no help, come let us kiss and part' as a helpless affair ~~that~~ - hence 'since there's no help' - and ~~that~~ a solemn loss for the speaker. ~~indicated through~~ This is indicated by the blunt tone taken on "you get no more of me" which suggests a sudden end to the relationship, portraying the process of ending a romantic affair as torturous, as if the speaker wishes the process itself to be over sooner than the actual relationship. This is further suggested by "thus so cleanly I myself can free." This suggests a sense of autonomy which would be conventional of a male poet who likely does not feel defined by their romantic endeavours the way a woman in the 16th century would be. However we feel a sense of grief from the speaker as he wishes to sever the relationship 'cleanly' - without any emotional damage. Monro's speaker seems unbothered by this claiming to be 'haunted by the person he is adressing,' and to 'loathe' the sight of a shadow "in the lamplight" as he is reminded of

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her. The final question, perhaps rhetorical of 'who waits, at the terrible door, but I?' indicates that the speaker believes he is settling for treatment or for a lover that NO one else would settle for, hence him withdrawing from the relationship - "I will not stay."

Overall, Drayton and Monro, despite their difference in time, portray the sense of loss that accompanies the end of a relationship through the depiction of liminal spaces and the process itself of leaving a relationship in a similar style.

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Student G

"Since there's no help, come let us kiss and part" by Michael Drayton and "The Terrible Door" by Harold Monro both explore the end of a relationship. While Drayton's Sonnet conveys a sense of satisfaction over the speakers divorce, Monro's poem expresses deep agony and eternal pining over an ended relationship.

The speaker in Draytons Sonnet can accept the ended relationship while the speaker in "The Terrible Door" cannot. "Since there's no help come let us kiss and part" is both the sonnet's title and opening line, expressing a sense of an amicable, mutual parting through the speakers use of the first person plural pronoun "us". Drayton's metaphor of a personifications of "love" "Passion" "Faith" and "Innocence" dying from the natural cause of a "pulse" failing presents the death of their relationship as a natural, inevitable end. His repetition of first person plural pronouns such as "we" and "our" when describing "canceling all our vows" suggest that both he and his former love have accepted the natural end of their love. By contrast, "The Terrible Door" immediately establishes a negative attitude from the speaker through the attributive adjective "terrible" in the title. The speaker describes themself as "haunted" by his lover's "ashen beauty" indicating that he cannot move on from her and equating his love to a ghost "haunting" him, so powerfull is his love. The interjections "happy release!" and "Good-bye forever" at the start of the final stanza take on an ironic tone, suggesting that he is pretending for her sake to accept the end of the relationship. this final statement "Who waits at the terrible door but I?" conforms through a rhetorical question that he will always want her back and will "wait" his whole life. The speakers of Drayton

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and Monro's poems express opposite attitude, surprisingly Drayton's is more accepting of a divorce, something uncommon in the 16th and 17th centuries*. Overall both writers explore different perspectives on ending relationships.

The speakers in both poems express some hope that their relationships might not be over forever. The speaker in Drayton's sonet, in the final rhyming couplet, contradicts his previous resignation to the end of the relationship by suggesting that the personification of love might "recover" "from death to life". The obvious impossibility of resurrection suggests inner conflict in the speaker in contradicting his own metaphor while also presenting the relationship unsavable except for a miracle. Drayton's sonnet is unconventional for the era in that it largely does not celebrate love or take a traditional romantic view of relationships, exploring the death of a relationship rather than beginning. The contradiction of the final rhyming couplet might suggest a desire to recapture the romance of contemporary poets such as Shakespeare but ultimately Drayton's poem presents this as unrealistic. This can be read as commentary on the contemporary love poetry. The hope of the speaker in "The Terrible Door" for the relationship to recommence is presented as tragic and fruitless. The imagery of him having "shivered" outside his lovers door "for too long" presents his obsessive love as self destructive and causing him suffering. The poem's ending returns to this image when the speaker expresses his desperate hope "if you want me, if you need me" using syntactic parallelism to emphasise his devotion to her. This hope leads the speaker to make his promise that he will always metaphorically wait at her door, suffering from his love, in case she needs him. Ultimately both writers explore hope that an ending relationship will restart but both ultimately present is as impossible, contradictory or self destructive.

Both writers explore body language during an ending suggesting a truly irreconcilable divide in the marriage*

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relationship. Drayton states that "not one jot of former love" is present on his or his wife's "brows" suggesting that they have lost their love through their facial expressions which have become sterile and unloving. Monro describes his former lover "[illegible]" taking "back [her] hand" as a sign of the loss of physical affection, they cannot touch, as if they were strangers. Overall both writers use body language imagery to evoke the loss of love.

Ultimately, both Drayton's Sonnet and Monro's poem explore the end of a relationship from a mans perspective as it ends but express different attitudes. Both however use similar techniques and end on the suggestion of hope, however misguided, to reunite with the former lover.

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Question 6 Paper 1, June 2024

'In the literature of love, opposites attract.'

In the light of this view, compare how lovers and their attraction to one another is presented in **two** texts you have studied.

You must write about **at least two** poems in your answer **as well as** the prose text you have studied.

[25 marks]

Mark scheme

It is important to remember that these students, in the main, are 18 years old so we are judging their skills at the end of Key Stage 5.

Weightings for each question are as follows:

AO1: 7 marks AO2: 6 marks AO3: 6 marks AO4: 3 marks AO5: 3 marks.

Mark	AO	Typical features	How to arrive at mark
Band 5 **Perceptive/Assured** **21–25 marks** '**Perception**' is demonstrated when students are showing the depth of their understanding and responding sensitively to the texts and task. '**Assuredness**' is shown when students write with confidence and conviction.	AO5	• perceptive and confident engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **perceptive** and **assured** work which shows confidence, sharpness of mind and sophistication in relation to the task. At the top of the band students are consistently **assured** and will demonstrate sensitivity and **perception** across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band there will be coherence and accuracy with some **perception** but with less consistency and evenness.
	AO4	• perceptive exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• perceptive understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • assuredness in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• perceptive understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • assured engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• perceptive, assured and sophisticated argument in relation to the task • assured use of literary critical concepts and terminology; mature and impressive expression	

Band 4 **Coherent/Thorough** **16–20 marks** '**Coherence**' is shown when students are logical and consistent in their arguments in relation to the task. They hold their ideas together in an intelligible way. '**Thoroughness**' is shown when students write carefully, precisely and accurately.	AO5	• thorough engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **coherent** and **thorough** work where ideas are linked together in a focused and purposeful way in relation to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a fully **coherent** and **thorough** argument across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band ideas will be discussed in a shaped, relevant and purposeful way with a clear sense of direction, with one or two lapses in **coherence** and accuracy.
	AO4	• logical and consistent exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• thorough understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • coherence in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• thorough understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • thorough engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• logical, thorough and coherent argument in relation to the task where ideas are debated in depth • appropriate use of literary critical concepts and terminology; precise and accurate expression	

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Band 3 **Straightforward/ Relevant** **11–15 marks** '**Straightforward**' work is shown when students make their ideas in relation to the task clearly known. '**Relevant**' work is shown when students are focused on the task and use detail in an appropriate and supportive way.	AO5	• straightforward engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **straightforward** and **relevant** work where the student's response to the task is clear and intelligible. At the top of the band students will demonstrate consistent **straightforward** understanding in the course of their argument. Ideas will be developed **relevantly**. At the bottom of the band there will be flashes of **relevant** understanding with evidence of **straightforward** thinking.
	AO4	• explores connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study in a straightforward way	
	AO3	• straightforward understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • relevant connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• straightforward understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • relevant engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• sensibly ordered ideas in a relevant argument in relation to the task • some use of literary critical concepts and terminology which are mainly appropriate; straightforward and clear expression	

Band 2 **Simple/Generalised** **6–10 marks** '**Simple**' work is shown when students write in an unelaborated and basic way in relation to the task. '**Generalised**' work is shown when students write without regard to particular details.	AO5	• simple and generalised response to the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **simple** and **generalised** work which is mainly linked to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a basic **generalised** understanding in the course of their answer. Ideas will be developed in a **simple** way. At the bottom of the band there will be inconsistency, but the beginnings of a **simple** and **generalised** understanding.
	AO4	• simple exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• simple understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • generalised connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• simple understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • generalised engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• a simple structure to the argument which may not be consistent but which does relate to the task • generalised use of literary critical concepts and terminology; simple expression	

Band 1 **Largely irrelevant/largely misunderstood/largely inaccurate** **1–5 marks** '**Largely irrelevant**' work is shown when students write in an unclear way with only occasional reference to what is required by the question. '**Largely misunderstood**' and '**largely inaccurate**' work is shown when knowledge of the text is insecure, hazy and often wrong.		• some vague points in relation to the task and some ideas about task and text(s) • the writing is likely to be unclear and incorrect; if it is accurate the content will be irrelevant • little sense of the AOs in relation to the task; little sense of how meanings are shaped; little sense of any relevant contexts; little sense of any connection arising out of historicist study; little sense of an argument in relation to the task	This band is characterised by work which is **largely irrelevant** and **largely misunderstood** and **largely inaccurate**, and so unlikely to be addressing the AOs in a relevant way. At the top of the band students will mention some unconnected points in relation to the task during the course of their writing. The writing is likely to lack clarity. At the bottom of the band there will be no connection with the task; the writing will be hard to follow and **irrelevant**.
0 marks		No marks for response when nothing is written or where response has no connection to the text(s) or task.	

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AO5 Explore literary texts informed by different interpretations

Students might consider:

- different kinds of attraction
- texts where lovers could be argued to be opposites or at least very different, perhaps to different degrees
- differences of age, class, background, personality and relationship history
- different kinds and degrees of physical and emotional attraction
- differences leading lovers to being complementary and compatible
- differences that lead to incompatibility despite the attraction
- texts where there is a revelation or realisation of opposition/attraction/compatibility/incompatibility and the effect of this on the narrative/poem
- texts where attraction is not dependent on opposition, perhaps on similarity
- etc.

AO4 Explore connections across literary texts

Focus might be on (in the literature of love):

- relevant genre-related comment on the ways in which poets and novelists present ideas about attraction
- similarity and/or difference at the level of subject matter
- similarity and/or difference at the level of prose and poetic methods and how writers present their thoughts and opinions
- the extent to which each text's presentation of attraction can be seen as typical of its genre, form or historical period
- etc.

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AO3 Demonstrate understanding of the significance and influence of the contexts in which literary texts are written and received

Focus might be on:

- reference to historical period
- ways in which social and cultural attitudes may be reflected in their chosen texts
- ways in which social and cultural attitudes may have changed over time
- reference to the gender of the writers and the ways they present attraction
- reference to how the differing male/female experience of attraction is presented
- aspects of text type and differences of genre context
- aspects of time and geographical setting
- etc.

AO2 Analyse ways in which meanings are shaped in literary texts

Students might focus on relevant aspects of:

- genre differences
- poetic methods
- prose methods
- etc.

AO1 Articulate informed, personal and creative responses to literary texts, using associated concepts and terminology, and coherent, accurate written expression

- quality of argument
- organisation of ideas
- use of appropriate concepts and terminology
- technical accuracy
- comparing texts.

Accept any valid interpretations, any valid comments on contexts and any valid discussion of authorial methods.

Note: Students must write about at least **two** poems from the poetry text to achieve a mark Band 4 or higher.

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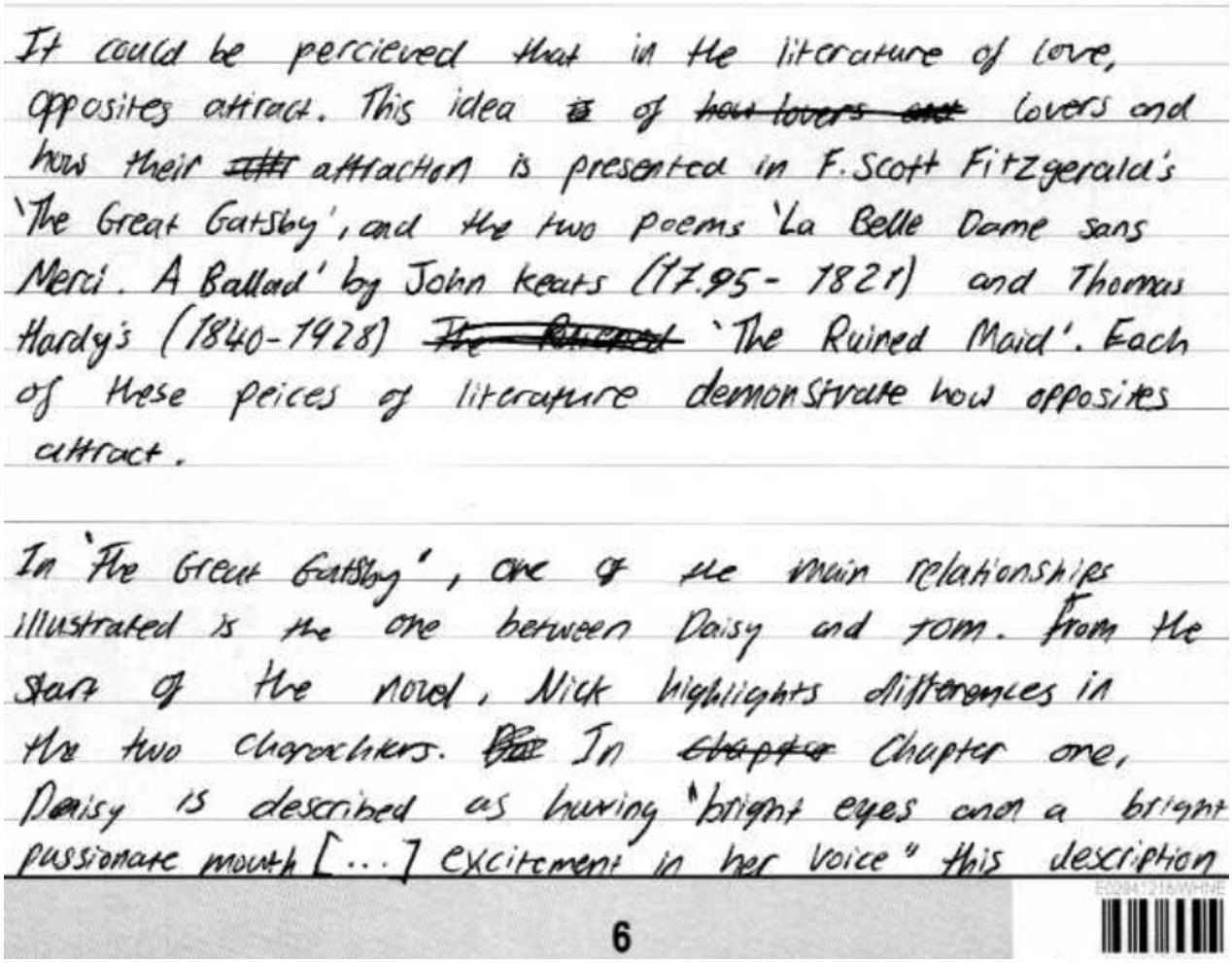
Student responses to mark

Student H



It could be percieved that in the literature of love, opposites attract. This idea ~~is~~ of ~~how lovers and~~ lovers and how their ~~attr~~ attraction is presented in F. Scott Fitzgerald's 'The Great Gatsby', and the two poems 'La Belle Dame sans Merci. A Ballad' by John Keats (1795 - 1821) and Thomas Hardy's (1840-1928) ~~The Ruined~~ 'The Ruined Maid'. Each of these peices of literature demonstrate how opposites attract.

In 'The Great Gatsby', one of the main relationships illustrated is the one between Daisy and Tom. From the start of the novel, Nick highlights differences in the two characters. ~~But~~ In ~~chapter~~ Chapter one, Daisy is described as having "bright eyes and a bright passionate mouth [...] excitement in her voice" this description

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of Daisy is almost a polar opposite to Nicks description of Tom. "His speaking voice, a gruff husky tenor', "rather hard mouth", and "Two shining arrogant eyes". There is clearly a physicalk difference between the twos appearances and attitudes which is highlighted through the words 'arrogant' and 'passionate' Not only this, but also the comparison of their voices.* ~~However~~ Another relationship Mentioned is that of Gatsby and Daisy, both of which have similar, kind personalities. The only true difference between the two of them was class. Daisy grew up with old money, Gatsby had to work for new money. This idea of opposite classes in relationships is also found in Hardy's 'The Ruined Maid'. 'Tired of diggring potatoes, and spudding up docks; And now you've gay bracelets and bright feathores theo!' the maid has had relations will a man of a higher class. She is attracted to being apart of the higher class through love. Hardy uses the comparison between 'diggring potatoes' and 'gay bracelets' to emphasise the true difference in class between her and her lover. This has strong relations to Gatsbys love for Daisy as he yearns to be with her despite her difference in class. It could be questioned wether the Maid and Gatsby are attracted to the opposite elements of their lovers or wether ~~they just~~ if they're just attracted to wealth and class.

In John Keats' 'La Belle Dame sans Merci. A Ballad' the opposition and difference lies between the knight being human and ~~the~~ his lover being 'a faery's child'. The knight was in love with her, despite not even understanding what she ~~was~~ was saying. 'in language Strange she said - 'I love thee true''. ~~The~~ His ~~love for her was so strong. I set her on my pacing steed. And through this grove, it's elves as if the knight~~

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~~has put her on a pedistal, he worships her. despite his attraction to the 'fairy's child' so~~
This quote demonstrates how deeply in love and how strong the knight's attraction to the 'fairy's child' is even though they are completly opossite in so many ways.

Overall, all three pieces of literature present lovers and their attraction to one another despite some being completly opposite to one another.

* However, ~~Both~~ both Daisy and TOM are part of the same class with old money. this almost contradicts the idea that opposites attract.

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Question 12 Paper 2B, June 2024

Compare the significance of loneliness and social isolation in **two** other texts you have studied.

Remember to include in your answer reference to how meanings are shaped in the texts you are comparing.

You must use **one** prose text and **one** poetry text in your response, at least **one** of which must be a text written post-2000.

You must write about **at least two** poems.

[25 marks]

Mark scheme

It is important to remember that these students, in the main, are 18 years old so we are judging their skills at the end of Key Stage 5.

Weightings for each question are as follows:

AO1: 7 marks AO2: 6 marks AO3: 6 marks AO4: 3 marks AO5: 3 marks.

Mark	AO	Typical features	How to arrive at mark
Band 5 **Perceptive/Assured** **21–25 marks** '**Perception**' is demonstrated when students are showing the depth of their understanding and responding sensitively to the texts and task. '**Assuredness**' is shown when students write with confidence and conviction.	AO5	• perceptive and confident engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **perceptive** and **assured** work which shows confidence, sharpness of mind and sophistication in relation to the task. At the top of the band students are consistently **assured** and will demonstrate sensitivity and **perception** across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band there will be coherence and accuracy with some **perception** but with less consistency and evenness.
	AO4	• perceptive exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• perceptive understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • assuredness in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• perceptive understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • assured engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• perceptive, assured and sophisticated argument in relation to the task • assured use of literary critical concepts and terminology; mature and impressive expression	

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Band 4 **Coherent/Thorough** **16–20 marks** '**Coherence**' is shown when students are logical and consistent in their arguments in relation to the task. They hold their ideas together in an intelligible way. '**Thoroughness**' is shown when students write carefully, precisely and accurately.	AO5	• thorough engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **coherent** and **thorough** work where ideas are linked together in a focused and purposeful way in relation to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a fully **coherent** and **thorough** argument across all five assessment objectives in the course of their response. At the bottom of the band ideas will be discussed in a shaped, relevant and purposeful way with a clear sense of direction, with one or two lapses in **coherence** and accuracy.
	AO4	• logical and consistent exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• thorough understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • coherence in the connection between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• thorough understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • thorough engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• logical, thorough and coherent argument in relation to the task where ideas are debated in depth • appropriate use of literary critical concepts and terminology; precise and accurate expression	
Band 3 **Straightforward/** **Relevant** **11–15 marks** '**Straightforward**' work is shown when students make their ideas in relation to the task clearly known. '**Relevant**' work is shown when students are focused on the task and use detail in an appropriate and supportive way.	AO5	• straightforward engagement with the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **straightforward** and **relevant** work where the student's response to the task is clear and intelligible. At the top of the band students will demonstrate consistent **straightforward** understanding in the course of their argument. Ideas will be developed **relevantly**. At the bottom of the band there will be flashes of **relevant** understanding with evidence of **straightforward** thinking.
	AO4	• explores connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study in a straightforward way	
	AO3	• straightforward understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • relevant connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• straightforward understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • relevant engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• sensibly ordered ideas in a relevant argument in relation to the task • some use of literary critical concepts and terminology which are mainly appropriate; straightforward and clear expression	

Band 2 **Simple/Generalised** **6–10 marks** '**Simple**' work is shown when students write in an unelaborated and basic way in relation to the task. '**Generalised**' work is shown when students write without regard to particular details.	AO5	• simple and generalised response to the debate set up in the task	This band is characterised by **simple** and **generalised** work which is mainly linked to the task. At the top of the band students will demonstrate a basic **generalised** understanding in the course of their answer. Ideas will be developed in a **simple** way. At the bottom of the band there will be inconsistency, but the beginnings of a **simple** and **generalised** understanding.
	AO4	• simple exploration of connections across literary texts arising out of historicist study	
	AO3	• simple understanding of the significance of relevant contexts in relation to the task • generalised connections between those contexts and the historicist literary concept studied	
	AO2	• simple understanding of authorial methods in relation to the task • generalised engagement with how meanings are shaped by the methods used	
	AO1	• a simple structure to the argument which may not be consistent but which does relate to the task • generalised use of literary critical concepts and terminology; simple expression	

Band 1 **Largely irrelevant/largely misunderstood/largely inaccurate** **1–5 marks** '**Largely irrelevant**' work is shown when students write in an unclear way with only occasional reference to what is required by the question. '**Largely misunderstood**' and '**largely inaccurate**' work is shown when knowledge of the text is insecure, hazy and often wrong.		• some vague points in relation to the task and some ideas about task and text(s) • the writing is likely to be unclear and incorrect; if it is accurate the content will be irrelevant • little sense of the AOs in relation to the task; little sense of how meanings are shaped; little sense of any relevant contexts; little sense of any connection arising out of historicist study; little sense of an argument in relation to the task	This band is characterised by work which is **largely irrelevant** and **largely misunderstood** and **largely inaccurate**, and so unlikely to be addressing the AOs in a relevant way. At the top of the band students will mention some unconnected points in relation to the task during the course of their writing. The writing is likely to lack clarity. At the bottom of the band there will be no connection with the task; the writing will be hard to follow and **irrelevant**.
0 marks		No marks for response when nothing is written or where response has no connection to the text(s) or task.	

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Students may choose to focus on representations of loneliness and representations of social isolation equally, or to prioritise either aspect of the task focus, or to concentrate on just one aspect

AO5 Explore literary texts informed by different interpretations

Focus might be on:

- representations of one or both of the key terms 'loneliness' and 'social isolation', as caused by, for example, aspects of society, culture, gender, race, nationality, disability, sexuality, religion or class, as expressed in their two texts
- the extent to which the contrasting genres of the two texts affect the ways in which various types of loneliness and social isolation are presented
- etc.

AO4 Explore connections across literary texts

Focus might be on:

- connections of similarity and/or difference at the level of subject matter/genre/attitudes and/or methods
- etc.

AO3 Demonstrate understanding of the significance and influence of the contexts in which literary texts are written and received

Focus might be on:

- relevant links to the shared historicist context of literature post-1945
- how various types and causes of loneliness and social isolation may be viewed differently over time
- how the theme of loneliness and social isolation contributes to a text or texts as a whole
- representations of various types and causes of loneliness and social isolation – eg as shown via character, scene, setting and/or situation – and their possible effects and impact
- the psychological effects of loneliness and social isolation; a comparison of characters who respond to loneliness and social isolation in various ways, eg overcoming or failing to cope with them
- etc.

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AO2 Analyse ways in which meanings are shaped in literary texts

Focus might be on:

- methods of presenting and explaining the reasons for the prevalence of the theme of loneliness and social isolation in modern literature
- possible purposes and effects of the presentation of loneliness and social isolation
- prose methods such as: narrative structure; point of view; chronology; use of dialogue; indirect speech; development of settings; ways of influencing the readers' response to character and incident
- dramatic methods such as: explicit structural devices; dramatic irony; stage directions; indirect ways of communicating the writers' messages and ideas; naturalistic, non-naturalistic, expressionist and other styles of representing character, incident and narrative
- poetic methods such as: types of verse form; explicit and implicit structural features; use of tropes for rhetorical effect; use of aural devices for rhetorical effect; elliptical use of language
- etc.

AO1 Articulate informed, personal and creative responses to literary texts, using associated concepts and terminology, and coherent, accurate written expression

- quality of argument
- organisation of ideas
- use of appropriate concepts and terminology
- technical accuracy
- comparing texts.

Accept any valid interpretations, any valid comments on contexts and any valid discussion of authorial methods.

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Student I

Both Atwood ~~Du~~ and Duffy explore loneliness and social isolation as ~~part of the~~ a significant part of the female experience ~~a~~ within patriarchal societies, in 'The Handmaids Tale' and 'Anon', respetively. ~~Atwood's~~ Duffy's ~~Feminist Gospels~~ post-modern collection sets out to present the idea of '... truth' as told by women on their experiences of social isolation. ~~whereas Atwood's speculative fiction~~ In contrast, Atwood's speculative fiction evisions a possible totalitarian state, and the loneliness and social isolation it induces amongst women.

In both 'The Handmaid's Tale' and 'Anon', Atwood and Duffy critique the control ~~over~~ imposed over women's identities, and how this causes women to be lonely and socially isolated from other women. As a typical dystopian novel, Atwood portrays social isolation ~~is~~ to be a prevalent ~~to be~~ theme throughout the novel. A poignant example is ~~Off~~ through Offred and Ofglen's interactions. Their dialogue is controlled by the oppressive regime of Gilead, 'Blessed be ... '/'... Lord open' which portrays their isolation from ~~each other~~ communicating with each other. Moreover, ~~the handm~~ Atwood utilises the costumes of the handmaids to portray their social isolation. For example, they are described as a 'shape, red ... the Race' and with 'white tunnels ... [them]' The use of this obscure imagery illustrates how

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the handmaids are all physically ~~a~~ isolated from each other, preventing them from communicating. ~~with~~ Thus, Atwood's novel can be seen as a sort of warning of the dangers of ~~so~~ social isolation inherent in oppressive societies. In a similar light, Duffy also illustrates the prevention of communication and social isolation in 'Anon'. Duffy's post-modern poem serves as a powerful exploration of ~~the control and destruction of~~ how the use of pseudonyms throughout publishing history kept female writers isolated and unrecognised. ~~Duffy~~ The speaker describes 'A girl ... on-/ Anon'. Duffy's use of rhyming 'bet' and 'net' illustrates the simple knowledge or view of the 'girl' and ~~how~~ perhaps how young girls are provided with insufficient knowledge of female writers, maintaing ~~their~~ & their social isolation. Moreover, ~~Duffy~~ Duffy's speaker describes 'A woman ... her skull' and swore that ... its chest.' Here Duffy uses this metaphor of the skull to represent the destruction of the female voice and how the dead writer is isolated, ~~as she is~~ rendering her unable to complain of her forced anonymity. Moreover, Duffy's use of the metonym 'Anon' alludes to Woolf's ~~her~~ assertion that 'Anon' who wrote so many texts 'without signing ... woman'. Thus, Duffy's ~~text~~ also serves as a powerful exploration of how ~~so~~ oppressive societies induce female isolation, but through the destruction of the female voice.

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~~Atwood and Duffy also~~ I would argue that ~~Th~~ Atwood and Duffy also propose how certain female figures act as a comforting force, helping to combat loneliness and social isolation. For example, throughout 'the Handmaids Tale' Atwood presents Moira as a brave female character who defies the rules and conventions of Gilead society. Moira is also present in Offred's thoughts, ~~which~~ 'Don't think ... would say' which shows how Moira 'provides a ~~kind~~ form of relief ~~for~~ for Offred and her loneliness. Moreover, Offred describes how, to her and the handmaids, 'Moira ... fantasy' and they 'hugged' her close, which made the Aunts appear less frightening. Atwood's use of the comforting tone evoked in this ~~desp~~ description presents Moira as a motherly, comforting figure that makes the handmaids feel less lonely and isolated from one another. A similar portrayal is ~~seen~~ evident in Duffy's poem 'The Long Queen' ~~when~~ where the heroic figure of Queen Elizabeth unites women, softening their loneliness and social isolation. Duffy describes 'what was ... hags,' matrons...' the asyndetic listing evoking a sense of union and 'togetherness' between all these different women. Moreover, Duffy presents the 'Long Queen' as motherly figure in the description ', no girl ... Queen's eye' which reinforces this feeling of union and affection amongst women. Furthermore, Duffy reinforces this portrayal in the final line 'All her ...

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time. Therefore, Duffy effectively conveys how strong, motherly female figures can combat social isolation ~~amongst~~ and loneliness amongst women, providing a feeling of comfort and togetherness.

In conclusion, both liberal feminists Atwood and Duffy present loneliness and social isolation as a ~~negative~~ prominent, ~~destructi~~ damaging force amongst ~~within~~ women within oppressive societies. Atwood's portrays a dystopian novel from a female perspective to explore the damaging force of social isolation. In contrast, Duffy's collection is clearly influenced by the post-modern theme of social isolation, and she uses this to focus on the particularly female experience. That being said, both texts ~~are~~ clearly depict the governing force of female sisterhood and its importance in ~~breaking pernea~~ breaking the barriers of loneliness and social isolation amongst women.

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Notes

If these exercises have prompted any questions, remember to make a note of them to ask at the event.

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Contact us

Our friendly team will be happy to support you between 8am and 5pm, Monday to Friday.

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